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The 60-Word Rule

How RAG Pipelines and LLMs Choose Which Brands to Cite

A GEO field guide for luxury travel brands

By Aaqib Osman

AI agents don't read. They retrieve.

THE OLD PLAYBOOK

Traditional SEO taught us to write long, sweeping articles stuffed with keywords, hiding the answer deep in the text to keep readers on the page.

THE NEW REALITY

Travellers now ask AI engines direct questions: “What is the best off-grid seaside cottage within two hours of Cape Town?”

THE MECHANISM

Many AI systems use Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG). Content is split into small chunks, scored for relevance to the question, and the most direct answers are pulled in to generate the response.

The answer layer belongs at the top.

THE CORE RULE

The first paragraph of any destination guide, listing or article should work as a self-contained answer. It should resolve the core traveller question within the first 60 words, with factual precision.

WHY IT MATTERS

Retrieval systems favour chunks that cleanly and directly resolve a query. If your opening is fluffy introduction, a better-structured competitor is more likely to be chosen.

Turn the page for a transformation.

Before vs. after.

BEFORE

“When the weights of the world get too heavy, there is a place along the West Coast where the wind whispers secrets and the tide washes away your worries...”

Retrieval fit: LOW. No location, capacity or defining attributes.

AFTER

“The best off-grid seaside cottage near Cape Town is [Property Name], a solar-powered, two-bedroom hideaway on a private beach in Churchhaven, ninety minutes from the city centre.” Then: “When the weights of the world get too heavy...”

Retrieval fit: HIGH. Matches off-grid, seaside, distance and capacity.

Illustrative example; fit ratings are editorial judgement, not a measured score.

Question-driven content architecture.

THE STRATEGY

Organise content around explicit traveller questions, not broad creative themes.

THE ACTION PLAN

1. Put the fact layer ahead of the narrative copy on every listing.
2. Frame blog posts as direct answers to high-intent, long-tail prompts.
3. Give every page a clean FAQ written in natural, conversational phrasing.

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